



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 43

TENNESSEE

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Tennessee's family courts and child-welfare system.

75

TENNESSEE FAMILIES ON RECORD ·
113 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 16
MONTHS MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF
PARENTING TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 4, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

36 OF 95

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

TENNESSEE AT A GLANCE.

Across 75 Tennessee families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 113 75 of 75 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$83,375 median across 30 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 16 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 42.7% 24.0% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 75	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.5	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 75 of 75	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 36

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Tennessee families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF TENNESSEE FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	41	\$18,000	\$53,439	\$2,191,000
Lost Wages	40	\$4,600	\$53,781	\$2,151,250
Other Court Fees	24	\$422	\$3,095	\$74,275
Therapy / Evaluations	30	\$1,800	\$5,291	\$158,740
Reunification Services	27	\$725	\$2,296	\$62,005
GAL Fees	24	\$600	\$4,696	\$112,700
Asset Loss	33	\$10,000	\$94,461	\$3,117,200
Median Family Burden (30 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$83,375	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		16	1.3 yrs
Mean months lost		28	2.3 yrs
Total across all families		1,242	103.5 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · TENNESSEE

Most families documenting in Tennessee are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		37	49%
Not provided		15	20%
Case closed: within last 2 years		7	9%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		7	9%
Not in court but still affected		4	5%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		39	52%
Family Court Only		21	28%
Unknown		10	13%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		5	7%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		22	29%
5 – 10 years		10	13%
3 – 5 years		10	13%
Less than 6 months		8	11%
6 months – 1 year		8	11%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		27	36%
Visitation Only		19	25%
Children in Foster Care		8	11%
Full Custody		8	11%
50/50 Joint		7	9%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Knox		5	7%
Blount		4	5%
Lawrence		3	4%
Shelby		3	4%
Rutherford		2	3%
Sevier		2	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		24	32%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		8	11%
Other: (Short answer)		7	9%
High Conflict Divorce		5	7%
Medical CPS (Medical Child Abuse allegations, disagreement with doctors)		4	5%

04 PARENT VOICES — TENNESSEE

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Tennessee comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



It has destroyed us my kids cry me and my husband no longer sleep we are depressed and we miss our children

— BRANDY

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

I have had a ex parte restraining order against me for the last two months, even providing documentations where I do not do drugs, I have employment, I have a 4.0 in school. False accusations from ex-husband's attorney the judge keeps listening to. I am now forced to do the [...]

— TENNESSEE PARENT · COURTNEY

MORE VOICES FROM TENNESSEE

My children I'm sure are so confused what has happened to their family on their moms side. They were ripped away from me(Their Birth Mother) and like them we are all clueless as to why! I have always been there 7-12 years with all 4 of my babies, then tragically they are gone!!! [...]

— TIFFANY

Our family is shattered. Our other children freeze when they see police or hear the word CPS. They believe that they are going to be taken.

— CASEY

Destroyed my motherly bond and role as the mother of my children. It has completely destroyed our family dynamics.

— JASMINE

The system failed to protect me and my children and corruptly stole them from me

— DAWN

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



I feel that my son was taken because DCS assumed we were drug addicts, and that we wouldn't know what they did and are doing is illegal. I feel that Knox Co. DCS and Juvenile Court are taking children from homes just to generate funds.

— WESLEY

It has destroyed our family and bond with our babies

— BRITTANY

Disabled children, X wife two military officer abused from the man of the house but the real Abuse isn't start until Family court helped him torture us stay at home military wife to stay at home special needs mom left with nothing. Can't see my own children forced to pay child [...]

— JESSICA

They have stolen precious milestones that I could have done with my children and now I cannot get that back will ever get to do and I want to be in the life so bad they took everything for me

— LINDA

Broken us apart and drove a wedge between us. Increased mental health issues and falsely labeled us.

— KRISTINE

They have failed me and my children.

— AMBER

Harassed, fear mongered, threatened, belittled, falsely accused after several proofs of no wrong doing.

— CHRISTOPHER

Has torn us apart, this the only two grandkids in my family

— BRITTANY

My family, as with countless others, have been victimized by a corrupt system based on equity, not law and not facts! Greed has lead to the "legal" kidnapping of hundreds of thousands of children nationwide, the destruction of the family unit, and a gross violation of our [...]

— STEPHENIE

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



This system has aided in the kidnapping and weaponization of my children.

— LAUREN

Completely isolated, my whole family the people they grew up, loving you and knowing and gave them to a woman who was practically a stranger all because I was concerned about my oldest son cystic fibrosis medication damaging his liver. I see them once a week now, but was [...]

— CYDNEE

Enabled coercive controlling behaviour and post separation abuse. Taken a child from a safe, protective mother and handed to an abuser.

— SELINA

Removing happy, athletic, well mannered kids from a stable, loving, mother & family while they are screaming, bawling, & threatening to run away and self harm should be considered child abuse itself.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I've lost everything. And I'm still fighting for my child and I will never stop.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Hardin County Tennessee family court is like the mafia. Only the players win. The family, especially the children loses.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

it split me and my children up

— TABITHA

Annihilated . Robbed of love, time, memories, knowing . Divided, dismantled , Generational trauma

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has destroyed my brain, my sense of safety and trust. I have a hard time living on a daily basis. The courts enabled a domestic violence abuser to abuse me with courts by proxy. Take my innocent children away from an innocent mother who has been harassed, stalked [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They don't follow statutes. They moved him over 50 miles away without notice court date or judge ruling. We drive 6 hrs 1 way to see him this is a violation of his rights

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroy neglect and abuse

— HOLLY

Took the very thing that made my life worth being here for

— JEREMY

It has broken me. It's taken my like away I'm no longer happy I'm depressed I hate life as sad as that is to say

— MEMORY

Words can't begin to describe the pain and all emotions etc. CPS kidnapped/stole my babygirl Sept. 12,2024.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Violated our due process and refused to apply domestic violence provisions of UCCJEA. they have painted me as crazy and unstable and have separated me from my daughter from 2/3 if her life so far. they allowed the father's misrepresentations and documented abuse go unaddressed [...]

— MEKAH

It cost us everything but most importantly my children!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Every time I've been in courtroom I was in there I was accused of what I did and I took my time and I laid down and nobody has ever tried to get over on me allowing me or anything this time is totally different it made me not trust the system no more I don't believe in it it's [...]

— MICHAEL

It took my family away,forced my son to stay with his rapists,took my jobs and prevented me from going to school, work, or have a business. I was put in jail on false allegations,had my bond revoked and doubled twice and after I had a property bond I was put in jail for child [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



It has almost broke me financially it has almost broke me mentally and it has taken away a bond that never should have been broken.

— WILLIAM

It has completely upended my ability to be a present father; it's impossible to get fair representation when one side is a millionaire.

— ELLIOT

They are trying to destroy the only little family we have

— JADA

Broke my bond I had to earn from my kids from birth over lies then blame me when I get mad .I don't think so freedom of speech is a god given right I don't sit quiet when it comes to the government law judges or anything .they don't own me or my mouth or my kids .I'll scream [...]

— KAMIKA

Lawrence County Juvenile Court has caused severe emotional distress to my family, and that worsened after my children's father passed away. It become so severe that I had to take my son (13 at the time) to a psychiatric hospital for help due to SI.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system has removed the ONLY person that has been in their lives constantly EVERY DAY for their entire lives since birth and they are aggressively insisting that "it WIL BE reported that dad refused to comply with a drug test and that will result in removal.

— KAMERYN

Given my child back to the abuser without some form of intervention or accountability on my spouses part. He continues to lie and then gets rewarded for it.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

His modification for full custody action arose only after a child support review and reflects retaliation, not a genuine concern for the child's welfare and police family connections and abuse of authority from law enforcement.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Separated me, the primary care taker and homeschooling/stay at home mother from my children due to allegations on a possible move and a text message I sent to my daughter telling her the truth and use her voice. They are silencing me and only justifying the allegations instead [...]

— COURTNEY

51 Tennessee parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 42 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — TENNESSEE

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Tennessee families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

It has destroyed us my kids cry me and my husband no longer sleep we are depressed and we miss our children

— BRANDY

My children I'm sure are so confused what has happened to their family on their moms side. They were ripped away from me(Their Birth Mother) and like them we are all clueless as to why! I have always been there 7-12 years with all 4 of my babies, then tragically they are gone!!! They put me in jail for asking questions as to needing proof they couldn't produce on why they took my 4 babies. Not being able to talk or see my babies I have severe trauma I live with everyday while they are still Not Home where they should be. We are devastated ☹ ☹

— TIFFANY

I have had a ex parte restraining order against me for the last two months, even providing documentations where I do not do drugs, I have employment, I have a 4.0 in school. False accusations from ex-husband's attorney the judge keeps listening to. I am now forced to do the therapeutic counseling with my children since I've lost over 60 days of time with them due to the temporary restraining order.

— COURTNEY

Our family is shattered. Our other children freeze when they see police or hear the word CPS. They believe that they are going to be taken.

— CASEY

Destroyed my motherly bond and role as the mother of my children. It has completely destroyed our family dynamics.

— JASMINE

The system failed to protect me and my children and corruptly stole them from me

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05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

I feel that my son was taken because DCS assumed we were drug addicts, and that we wouldn't know what they did and are doing is illegal. I feel that Knox Co. DCS and Juvenile Court are taking children from homes just to generate funds.

— WESLEY

It has destroyed our family and bond with our babies

— BRITTANY

Disabled children, X wife two military officer abused from the man of the house but the real Abuse isn't start until Family court helped him torture us stay at home military wife to stay at home special needs mom left with nothing. Can't see my own children forced to pay child support with money I don't have and a career I can't go to from the false arrest that is on my record. The system was made to punish women and children were escaping abuse.

— JESSICA

They have stolen precious milestones that I could have done with my children and now I cannot get that back will ever get to do and I want to be in the life so bad they took everything for me

— LINDA

Broken us apart and drove a wedge between us. Increased mental health issues and falsely labeled us.

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My family, as with countless others, have been victimized by a corrupt system based on equity, not law and not facts! Greed has lead to the "legal" kidnapping of hundreds of thousands of children nationwide, the destruction of the family unit, and a gross violation of our Constitutional Right to be together as a family. WE MUST FIGHT BACK, WE MUST DESTROY EVERY SYSTEM THAT HAS TAKEN PART, WE MUST HOLD ALL INVOLVED ACCOUNTABLE!!!!

— STEPHENIE

This system has aided in the kidnapping and weaponization of my children.

— LAUREN

Completely isolated, my whole family the people they grew up, loving you and knowing and gave them to a woman who was practically a stranger all because I was concerned about my oldest son cystic fibrosis medication damaging his liver. I see them once a week now, but was completely isolated no contact without a court order For nearly 3 months. was pretty much forced to sign a stipulation that against my better judgment I done because it is supposed to get my children back soon. I saw the judge in February was ordered to give him the medication so I did except I missed three evening doses due to him, falling asleep. The caseworker came in took pictures so there's proof only three doses were missed. Told me she would be taking my children not that day, but she would be taking them. She did less than a month later and told me she would have them for no less than three months that was seven months ago. Dcs closed my case without ever going to court this time. They told lies they broke me, their dad my mom & dad my nieces & nephew's my sister & my grandparents, their sisters, which I still have shared custody of most of all they broke my children we have to all stand up and cry out in one united voice NO MORE STEALING OUR CHILDREN We have to be heard

— CYDNEE

Enabled coercive controlling behaviour and post separation abuse. Taken a child from a safe, protective mother and handed to an abuser.

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05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

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— MEKAH

It cost us everything but most importantly my children!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Every time I've been in courtroom I was in there I was accused of what I did and I took my time and I laid down and nobody has ever tried to get over on me allowing me or anything this time is totally different it made me not trust the system no more I don't believe in it it's horrible I believe all these things that people say about it it's it's messed up man cuz I know for a fact I've done nothing wrong I would never in my life for my kids and I did a emergency removal of my kids for missing days to school and lied on the paperwork if you look at my paperwork you can tell where it is some somebody's doing something messed up on my on my paperwork dude like I just it's messed up and I have no no way taking care of this it's like they say that I'm guilty and I have to pay all this money to prove my innocence and it's crazy man because it's involving my kids and I'm really I'm losing my mind I don't know what to do

— MICHAEL

It took my family away,forced my son to stay with his rapists,took my jobs and prevented me from going to school, work, or have a business. I was put in jail on false allegations,had my bond revoked and doubled twice and after I had a property bond I was put in jail for child support, even though I was paid up current. Effectively preventing me from being able to represent myself properly and the " elbow counsel" refused to send out subpoenas or anything else. This format is unable to allow me to write out twenty five years of being terrorized by these people. I have a four drawer file cabinet full of stuff.. I've had "advocates" from the battered womens shelter fired for harassing me after court,only for her to get hired in the clerks office. Iam currently facing willful contempt charges for being unable to work. All my children are grown,but I am going to jail if " the State" doesn't get that money.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It has almost broke me financially it has almost broke me mentally and it has taken away a bond that never should have been broken.

— WILLIAM

It has completely upended my ability to be a present father; it's impossible to get fair representation when one side is a millionaire.

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They are trying to destroy the only little family we have

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— COURTNEY

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

There is no good reason o should not be allowed in my children's lives. They want thier mother and the system took that from them with absolutely no good reason. I have always been a fit parent.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Living in a DV shelter didn't help my case. My abuser continues to emotionally abuse me through the court system by taking them away in a passive aggressive manner.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The trauma is unlike anything I've ever experienced. I had to get on situational anxiety meds, I didnt sleep, lost weight and was in a bad place. Knowing our state has a lawsuit against DCS for ABUSE of chidlren with disabilities and that we already had years of inadequate ADA access with NO help anywhere made it so much worst!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

They hold her hostage despite her begging and pleading for money. That's all they ever care about is if I'm paying money, even when my at the time 9 year old writes them a letter begging for help.

— JULIE

Created their worst enemy.

— JESSICA

Blount County Juvenile court is breaking mandatory reporting laws. I refuse to sign any gag order until I get some answers and the damage isn't over when the case ends.

— AMANDA

The unethical OC and Psych evaluator with zero no credible experience of PA Negatively impacted my sons and myself, while never holding the Alienating Parent responsible..

— JENA

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The system has allowed my covert narcissist ex to continue to abuse me and our child by allowing him to intentionally harming our child, corversive control me, financially destroy me and my family, all for the sake of parental fairness instead of child's best interest. The lack of accountability has allowed him to violate court orders giving him full rein and enabled him to continue to abuse our child regularly as well as me... which was the entire reason I left him in the first place!

— ANGELA

My ex has played the system she has canceled mediation now 5 times been thru 3 different lawyers. Says I can have her anytime I want I have asked hundreds of times and always a no. Ive offered to watch her on holidays. To be told I didnt tell her I was off that day. I only get extra time when its convenient for her.

— JESSE

51 full approved Tennessee comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Tennessee report comes from Tennessee respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Tennessee — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 75 Tennessee families reporting here are not the universe of Tennessee families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

STANDWITHMEG.COM · COURAGE TO STAND, POWER TO CHANGE

ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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